ROCKET BOY

Bakhtiar K. Dadabhoy's biography of Homi J. Bhabha tries to tease out the man behind the myth—in remarkable detail

In *Homi J. Bhabha: A Life*, Bakhtiar K. Dadabhoy tells the tale of the boy-with-the-active-brain, who grew up to become a renowned physicist and the father of India's nuclear energy programme. While Bhabha is a familiar and feted figure in India—popping up in school textbooks and lists of great Indians—this sprawling biography seeks the man behind the official memory.

Dadabhoy also attempts to use Bhabha's life as a "vehicle for telling the story of Indian science" and tracing the "trajectory of India in the twentieth century". He painstakingly recreates lost times—recounting the history of the Parsi community, delving into abstruse scientific concepts, and describing the bitter politics that plagued the scientific community in India.

Born into a Parsi family in Bombay, Bhabha grew up in a prosperous and westernised environment. Even as a child, his curiosity and spirit were evident—as when he wanted to jump from the first floor of his home, using an umbrella as a parachute. As a schoolboy, he developed a lifelong passion for art and Western classical music. And as a student at Cambridge, he discovered his love for physics and his dislike of mechanical engineering (he got a third class in his mechanical engineering exam but struck a deal with his father—a first class in his next exam in exchange for permission to stay on in Cambridge and study mathematics).

Flamboyant, confident and a heartbreaker, Bhabha didn't fit the stereotype of the diffident "colonial scientist"—a fact that sometimes irked his White contemporaries. Even so, his research was lauded, and he was gaining recognition in Europe.

Then WWII broke out and Bhabha found himself stuck and fretting in India. Gradually, however, the safe parachute of a research job in Europe was discarded in favour of a risky umbrella. Bhabha began to dream of a school of physics in India "comparable with the best anywhere". For the next two decades, Bhabha did all he could to realise and nurture his dream. The outcome was the remarkable Tata Institute of Fundamental Research (TIFR) in Mumbai.

Dadabhoy points out that while TIFR was born out of Bhabha's brilliance, it also suffered from his autocratic approach. Through the book—which ends with Bhabha's untimely death in a plane crash—Dadabhoy provides multiple voices and perspectives. This research is the book's strength, but also contributes to its weakness. Dadabhoy seems loath to leave out a single anecdote or conference paper and has stuffed the pages with names, details and tangential asides.

It is this tendency that makes the book a mixed read—compelling at times, but so cluttered at others that it becomes difficult to follow the narrative thread. ■

Shabnam Minwalla



FRUITS OF THE BARREN TREE
by Lekhnath Chhetri (translated from the Nepali by Anurag Basnet)
PENGUIN
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loves, and his village. Nimma hopes that one day he will turn over a new leaf. But little can she imagine that when Jhuppay agrees to rent his loudspeaker for a political rally to earn an honest wage, he will unwittingly unleash a spiral of violence.

The book revolves around the mid-1980s, when Darjeeling district was aflame with an armed movement centred around the idea of *jaati* (community), with a separate state as the goal. With the clear message that anyone who questioned it was against the revolution, the violence swept through and irrevocably changed the lives of people. The State came down brutally, often enabling opponents of the movement. "Along with the khaki uniforms and the weapons, the police also distributed courage." The only policeman named, ACP Honda, is still remembered with a shudder. Wily 'area conveners' and opportunists emerged; they held sway through both jingoistic slogans and a heavy hand. As a tale of a movement that lost its moorings, the novel takes a hard look at the leaders who made speeches "high up on a mountain far from" Jhuppay and his neighbours. Later, they would use the sentiments they whipped up "as currency to build beautiful bungalows" while the common citizen was left to gaze at them.

Otherwise written in spare prose, the novel's evocative descriptions of the hills, rivers, fields and forests give it a strong sense of place. Basnet, the translator, has done a fine job, and apart from one or two clunky sentences, the text flows easily. Placing the Nepali and English word side by side ("doko basket", "dubo grass", "gagro water-jar", etc.) is a smart move. However, the proofreading is sloppy. Errors abound; the names of characters differ, in one instance in the next page itself.

Basnet's advice could well be the author speaking to himself too. Perhaps enough time has passed for survivors and their descendants to process the memories of those violent days in the written word. Chuden Kabimo's *Song of the Soil* (translated from the Nepali by Ajit Baral) is set in the same time period. These novels are important records of those dark days whose shadows still haunt the hills. And when written with such power, it makes the reading that much more fulfilling. ■

Vineeta Rai

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